

Ontology

or

The System of the Categories*

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INTRODUCTION.

The introduction to metaphysics, in the proper sense of the word, is a peculiar [189] philosophical discipline, one that develops the various stages through which human consciousness runs from its immediate shape up to the level of cultivation at which metaphysics takes its beginning. Such a philosophical propaedeutic Hegel gave in his *Phenomenology of Spirit*; but that work, through the manifoldness of its content, far oversteps the boundaries marked out by that definition, and moreover presupposes readers who have an acquaintance with the history of philosophy. Other philosophers too have, under various names, given presentations of the philosophical propaedeutic in that sense. The most distinguished are due to J. E. von Berger, C. F. Krause, and J. H. Fichte. In a certain sense, then, metaphysics cannot be called the beginning of philosophy, since the propaedeutic must, in a suitably arranged exposition of the system of philosophy, be sent on ahead. This science is meant, namely, to lead the [190] reader to the boundaries of metaphysics and so to orient him that he clearly recognizes into which region he is now to be conducted. It is to teach him to understand what is meant when the thinking he is now called upon to follow is termed immanent or a priori thinking. With respect to the natural order of the didactic exposition, the

*This is how the author designates the science he lectured on, in the announcement of his lectures on it in the winter half-year of 1837.

propaedeutic is thus to be regarded as the first discipline of the system of philosophy; on another consideration, metaphysics must be called the beginning of philosophy. For it proceeds from the most universal determinations of thought valid for all reality, determinations that must be presupposed in the more concrete concepts gone through in the propaedeutic. In concept, therefore, metaphysics is the truer beginning, to which that preparatory science goes back.

Metaphysics, then, can not only, like every philosophical discipline, be expounded on the strength of its relative self-sufficiency in such a way that, taken by itself, it becomes intelligible; it can, with greater right than any other part of philosophy, in its isolated shape make a claim to intelligibility. For its determinations are repeated, in more concrete shapes, in all the parts of philosophy, while it itself contains the simplest elements of all cognition. When the propaedeutic, by leading up to the region in which metaphysical thinking moves, has performed its service, the propaedeutic may be lost from view like a ladder that has fulfilled its purpose. The new thinking to which one now turns is namely no longer conditioned by that introduction, but comes forward as wholly presuppositionless and immediate. As a consequence, the thoughtful reader who follows the exposition of metaphysics with his attention (even if he does not, at its very beginning, at once notice in what sphere he finds himself) will, in the course of its advance, come to understand the light that the various propositions, by their mutual connection, cast upon one another.

On the few pages to which I have here given the name of Introduction, it is naturally [191] not my intention to follow the train of thought demanded by a rigorous, scientific propaedeutic. I merely send ahead a couple of aphoristic remarks, by which I believe I may awaken in one reader or another a preliminary representation of the content of metaphysics and of its significance within the whole system of science. Whether these introductory considerations meet with points of contact in the reader's circle of consciousness, or not, is entirely accidental. Of them holds what holds of aphorisms in general: they are like hats made without measurement; it is a stroke of luck whether any of them fits a given individual's head, or not.

If, for one acquainted with the critical philosophy, one were to set out a preliminary concept of the principal part of metaphysics that is to be expounded here, one could give him the information that it aimed at a systematic deduction of the categories; for, with the addition of a few closer determinations, that definition would give him a

tolerable representation of the content of the science (of the writing). In the critical philosophy one strove, namely, to give an inventory of the concepts that lie at the ground of thinking and that are not given through sensory sensation. These concepts Kant sought to bring to consciousness by reflection on the various forms of judgments. For this investigation he laid at the ground the division of judgments familiar from the usual logics (namely the one that takes account of their quality, quantity, modality, and relation). It was taken in his philosophy as a matter of fact that those concepts are presupposed in all thinking that posits objective reality. But he makes no attempt to show how it lies in the nature of the case that thinking comes forward precisely in these forms. Nor does he give any particular account of these concepts' mutual relation to one another; although the question would naturally have to be raised whether [192] these concepts are merely coordinate with one another without further connection, or whether they stand to one another as universal and particular. — Kant himself gives occasion for this question, in that he, in passing, loosely throws out the remark that the third category in every class arises through a combination of the first and the second. But this loosely thrown-out thought, on which Kant himself lays no weight, prompts one strongly to ask further what relation the various classes of categories then have to one another. Such riddles are voiced, more or less definitely, all through the development of the critical philosophy, where they were summed up in the definite demand for a deduction of the categories.

But in taking this refuge in the idiom of the critical philosophy, it is of particular importance that one strike out of one's head every representation of the subjectivity of the categories. Kant assumed, namely, that these concepts, which lie at the ground of thinking, are merely forms that are necessary for the human being if he is to be able to ascribe objective reality to his sensory representations, without these therefore holding, as true determinations, for the thing in itself. This purely arbitrary assertion is recognized as invalid in a correct presentation of ontology.

The determinations that, in the thinking of existence, carry with them complete conviction hold necessarily for the thing in itself. If one does not accept this proposition as correct, one is entangled in a doubt that, consistently pursued, cancels itself. One cannot, indeed, refute the skeptic who, at every step of a scientific train of thought, stubbornly holds fast to the remark that human thinking is bound to subjective laws, in accordance with which it forms for itself only crooked concepts of the nature and

essence of things; for against every conceivable proof he need only utter his formula, ready once and for all: “Thus I am compelled, according to my subjectivity, to think to myself the essence of things; but who can vouch to me that I am not, without knowing it, bound to the fate of being led to merely errant thoughts that nevertheless, for me, carry complete conviction.” — Science can indeed utter, for that absolute skeptic, a worldview according to which the conviction of the reality of thinking is strengthened by a concept of the significance of thinking within existence and of its springing from the object of religion, the all-comprehending Essence; but the skeptic can, once the concept has been uttered, come forward anew with his simple formula: “Thus we must think to ourselves the fundamental relations of existence, but perhaps in themselves they are not such as we must think them.” — We are then obliged to answer that skeptic, who believes that with a single magic formula he can annihilate all the fruits of scientific thinking: Let it, then, be possible that the use of reason leads to mere delusion — a possibility that, taken by itself, can as little be disputed as many another, e.g. the one that the moon is a glowing stone — yet we philosophize under the presupposition that what, for a rational thinking, carries conviction holds for the thing in itself. We assume, then, once and for all, that what rational beings must necessarily think to be, necessarily is, just as it must be thought; and we desire no surer science than the one that, for us, carries complete conviction. — After these restrictions and corrections, we may provisionally let that definition stand, that ontology is a deduction of the system of the categories. [193]

For a natural philosopher of the Schellingian school, ontology is best explained as the elucidation (development) of the concept of the Absolute. For in Schelling’s philosophy this concept appears without any introduction, and the few determinations by which it is elucidated are wholly unintelligible to one who has no acquaintance with the philosophical movements that preceded natural philosophy. Only through this historical knowledge can the concepts *intellectual intuition*, *the Absolute*, *subjectivity*, *objectivity*, *etc.*, of which Schelling makes an immediate use, have any definite meaning for the reader. This lack has also often enough been marked with the apt expression that metaphysics or ontology was wanting among the natural philosophers. [194]

The various definitions of the Absolute, found here and there in Schelling’s many writings, would naturally have to be brought together by the attentive reader. The Absolute is now designated as the identity of the ideal and the real, now as the

identity of unity and opposition, now as the bond between unity and manifoldness, now as the identity of essence and form, or of the affirming and the affirmed, and so forth. But there is no clear consciousness at all of the meaning of these various fundamental concepts and of their relation to one another. And yet it is sometimes clear from the context that it is the nature of the matter itself that brings Schelling, in new regions of his system, suddenly to alter the terminology he had hitherto used. To this indeterminacy and instability in the designation of the concepts there is added, moreover, the awkward circumstance that the names of natural phenomena are frequently used in place of pure determinations of thought, as when the words *Light* and *Gravity* are not taken in their usual meaning but are used to designate fundamental concepts within the system.

Since the age no longer found itself satisfied with the half-poetic form in which Schelling had presented his intuition of the nature and essence of the Absolute (especially after a swarm of imitators had brought the defects of the presentation to clear consciousness), G. W. Hegel attacked and carried out the great work of developing all the fundamental concepts of philosophy in systematic connection. By his labors the idea of ontology, in the form that the present shape of philosophy requires, has been reborn in the philosophical world. The consequence of this has also been that [195] the several distinguished philosophers who, in our time, have given presentations of this reawakened science have, more or less, made use of his preliminary labors and formed themselves after the great model he set up in his *Wissenschaft der Logik*.

The aim of ontology, then, becomes that of bringing to scientific clarity all the concepts of which philosophy must make use in the complete definition of the Absolute. The Absolute is therein to be considered according to the universal determinations of its content, without regard to the special forms under which it comes forward in time and space. All the concepts that, according to their deeper meaning, can be thought as essential predicates of the Absolute are to be grasped according to this meaning and to yield a contribution toward a construction of cognition in the light of the Absolute.

We have said above that ontology is a self-contained circle of thought which, by a clear presentation, can, like every other philosophical discipline, be made intelligible taken by itself, although greater clarity is shed upon it when it is seen in its organic connection with the whole system of philosophy. But though ontology has such a relative self-sufficiency that it can be understood of itself, in that its various parts cast

the necessary light upon one another, it is not thereby said that a reader who is devoid of all philosophical culture at once grasps its very first propositions. If such a reader at once, at the beginning of the exposition, finds himself oriented and notices in which region of thought he finds himself, this must be regarded rather as a stroke of luck than as an effect that can be counted on and that lies in the nature of the matter.

But it is not likely that this writing will be read by very many who wholly lack acquaintance with the elements of philosophy. On the contrary, I hold it probable that most of those who will lend it any attention have read or studied Professor Sibbern's [196] most important works. For such readers a few more considerations are sent ahead, in which but one concept is laid at the ground as wholly familiar — I mean the concept: a priori concepts, or categories. It is here taken as a settled matter that at the ground of all cognition there lies a portion of concepts that do not present any content given through sensory sensation. Every kind of thinking, in the broad sense of the word, has at every step of its development such categories among its presuppositions, and applies them, even without consciousness of it, in every one of its movements. We have said that these concepts lie at the ground of all cognition. This proposition has quite literal truth and complete universal validity; for all cognition comes to actuality as thinking, and thinking consists in an application of a priori presuppositions that spring solely from thinking itself and lead its activity forward. By these categories, determinations are cognized in actuality which are there only for thinking, and which yet, for the thinking subject, carry the same conviction of objective validity as the determinations that, in consequence of affections of the nervous system, are ascribed to things. Thinking pervades cognition at every one of its stages of development: not even a single act of outward sensing can take place except in such a way that the subject distinguishes something existing from itself and posits it as something for itself, distinct from another existing thing; but here at once several categories come into application, namely the concepts: existence, being-for-itself, etc.

There is, in the development of consciousness, a period in which the human being thinks according to his categories with complete assurance, without misgiving or doubt about their proper meaning. In this state of innocence of thinking, these concepts constitute the firm supports about which the development of cognition turns, but which are themselves exempt from the unrest of the movement. Even after the human being has, by reflection on the presuppositions of thinking and by imitation of [197]

foreign speech that goes beyond his understanding, lost that sure tact for their proper use, a good portion of the most abstract categories still retain their full meaning for him. Nor was it conceivable that all the categories in a human being's consciousness should at once be brought into confusion and dissolution without derangement being the inevitable consequence thereof.

So long as thinking retains that merely natural soundness, consciousness can naturally answer more or less to its idea. The clarity with which the a priori concepts come to development in the individual at this standpoint depends first of all on the richness and definiteness that prevails in the vocabulary of the mother tongue, and next on the shape under which language first comes to his ear in his circle of intercourse. One who is awakened to self-consciousness by a language so poor in determinations of thought as the Greenlandic is set, by an unavoidable fate, on a low level of intellectual culture, above which his individual natural gifts are not able to raise him very far.

We are speaking here of the categories as they first show themselves, when they are merely immediately held fast in definite forms within language. They are then best regarded as a tradition, as the common property of a tribe of people, as its intellectual patrimony and one of the most characteristic expressions of the whole people's power of thought. The categories come, indeed, first to the individual as a tradition within language, but are not therefore taken up by it as something foreign. When this tradition is appropriated by a well-endowed individual, it finds therein, on the contrary, a form for its own thinking, which it uses as surely as if it had itself produced it. It thinks independently in the forms that belong to the tribe, forms that are no more the one individual's property than the other's, because they are a form of the universal reason, which has actuality only in that it repeats itself in the thinking of the particular individuals. The individual thinks for himself when he thinks in his tribe's forms of thought; for his rational life consists only in connection with the rational life of a society, whose great stream flows also through his individual consciousness. [198]

In the application of the categories, and in reflection on the categories in its consciousness that have not lost their immediate meaning, the thinking subject feels itself in its own element, more than in items of knowledge about the sensory determinations of things: of this an immediate consciousness must be able to convince every thinking subject. When it receives the knowledge that a thing is red or sour, this knowledge is

outward for it in a different sense than when it recognizes that one phenomenon is cause and another effect. Thinking feels itself otherwise disposed toward itself when it reflects on the concepts unity, plurality, ground, consequence, etc., than when it considers the sensory predicates ascribed to existing things. The first-named concepts are, namely, thinking's own products; it recognizes in them the firm traces of its own activity; it feels itself here at home in a different way than when it has to do with representations and concepts that present merely the content of sensory affections.

The categories can come forward either in a vulgar way or with a higher meaning. In the first place they can lie at the ground of thinking in the period of merely natural consciousness. They are then used, as the turn comes to them, each by itself, according to a sound tact of the thinking subject, while it grasps its circle of experience in a sensory and understanding way, or utters its religious knowledge in a popular form. It is unable to form for itself representations of the objects that, in the surrounding world, present themselves to its senses, without its intuition constantly entering into union with a thinking that proceeds from the categories as its firm presuppositions. Here the a priori concepts show themselves precisely as wholly clear and intelligible to thinking; [199] for although the concepts existence, cause, effect, etc. here continually come into application, no need is felt at this standpoint for their explanation: in this period one never asks what existence, cause, effect mean; it is here understood of itself; for one has to do, in these concepts, with the means of one's own understanding. One thinks merely of understanding things, not of understanding one's own understanding. Thus one has often, here in Denmark, even quite recently, carried on a heated dispute about the proper boundary between rote learning and understanding in popular religious instruction, without the disputing parties' having expressed the least doubt that they understood one another's concept of understanding. On the contrary, they had with assurance laid this concept at the ground as a firm, common point of departure for their inquiries. Even in the period in which the system of the categories is disturbed by reflections and is in part held fast by isolated definitions, they can nevertheless still stand in the service of vulgar thinking. This they do, namely, so long as they are used, as isolated, firm points of departure, in the grasping of the phenomena of the given actuality.

A deeper meaning a category acquires when it is grasped as a determination for all actuality. Such a universal meaning one finds that now one, now another category

has won in the history of science. Sometimes, namely, one individual or another has suddenly seen the validity of such a concept for everything that is, when it is thought in its totality. It has, by such a single determination, embraced the whole of actuality in its thinking, and held that it had thereby fully grasped it in its truth. Thus several philosophers have with enthusiasm defended the proposition that All was One, and have lived in the conviction that in this concept of unity they had found the key to the whole riddle of existence. But such a one-sided doctrine has usually called forth [200] an equally forceful presentation of the proposition, for an outward consideration wholly opposed to it, that what in truth is is an infinite manifoldness. (We choose here, namely, an example that, as is well known, was already brought forward by the Xenophontic Socrates, when he with few words emphasized the great contradiction that obtained among the principles of the philosophers.) — But when a thinker holds that in a single category he has discovered the true concept of actuality, there lies in his opinion both truth and error. It is truth that a single category can be so thought that one has in it a moment of the concept of actuality, which can be laid at the ground of a worldview. It is incorrect, on the other hand, that he denies to other categories the same universal meaning. The expressly uttered category designates only one of the sides of a priori cognition; but he who, in such a single word, finds a satisfying form for his cognition means, by his word, much more than is uttered thereby. Were he in a position to bring the one-sidedness of his cognition to clear consciousness, he would with the same stroke have come to the insight that he had to proceed to an opposite determination, which had just as universal a meaning. But the mutually opposed determinations are united in a third, more correct category, in which the two preceding ones are both preserved in their relative validity. The third, fuller category is, by continued thinking, likewise recognized as one-sided, passes over into its opposite, and thereupon forms, in union with it, a new, more complete category.

(By these few words a preliminary representation is given of the method of ontology, which will gain clarity through the presentation of the science itself. Besides, I intend, partly in the course of the exposition, partly at its conclusion, to permit myself a number of elucidating reflections, with the aim of bringing the method to clear consciousness.)

By such a movement of thought one comes to a system of a priori concepts, [201] which, when the beginning is thought as the concept of all actuality, retains in a more

developed form the universal meaning, or presents a cognition “*sub specie æternitatis*.” In such a system of concepts an original cognition of actuality is uttered, because therein is determined what must always and necessarily be thought in actuality, however it may otherwise present itself. Such an a priori circle of thought, which constitutes the content of ontology, gives the result that personality is actuality thought in its truth, or that nothing is with truth to be called actual except what has personality. But only in the movement through the whole cycle of single determinations does it become clear what actuality is and what personality is; for at this place we have only presupposed that each of these words itself carries an immediate meaning. By such an a priori movement of thought a twofold gain is achieved. In the first place, the a priori concept of actuality is completely explained. Account is namely given of how actuality must be thought always, or under the form of eternity: account is given, in such a way, of the fact that it is only at the conclusion of the exposition that it is uttered what one understands by the proposition that actuality is personality. This proposition must, at the conclusion of the exposition, have won a different meaning from the one with which it can here be uttered without preparation. — In the second place, the single categories are with the same stroke explained, when they are, in the course of the exposition, defined in their place and by their place in the whole connection. For one who, after having thought through each fundamental concept according to its meaning in the ontological circle of thought, turns again to empirical and to practical thinking, these fundamental concepts, although they are used in the same combinations in which the natural tact of language chose them, have acquired a deeper meaning; for even to the sphere of daily life he now brings the light with which ontology has pervaded them.¹ [202]

¹Ontology is the doctrine of the eternal form of thinking and of existence: it presents, namely, the universal determinations that hold for everything that is, which All at the same time — as the following presentation of the science will show — carries with it the determinations with which we have here and there, in the foregoing, by anticipation designated it, namely existence, actuality. In the development and explanation of the constantly valid determinations for the actual, God and the world and God’s relation to the world are at the same time thought in abstract concepts, i.e. thought in general, without therefore the whole concrete content of actuality being taken up into the ontological form of thought. Just as the thinker in a single category has often thought All under the form of eternity, but in such a way that his thinking in an abstract manner embraces therein all actuality, so too is the whole of existence thought abstractly in the whole system of a priori concepts, which indeed with objective validity determines all actuality, but does not present the whole richness of existence. (Without granting any individual arbitrary power to determine the usage that is to be used in the free republic of philosophy, we use this many-meaning word — abstract — here in a sense that has

Ontology utters, as has been said, one principal moment of scientific cognition: [203] but the second principal moment of the latter is experience. Only the experience that has the thoroughly worked-through system of categories for its presupposition, or the a priori thinking that is united with sympathy and with the cognition of actual persons, is the energy of human cognition. The one-sided a priori thinking of thinking is not divine, but in worth below the true human thinking. Experience without pure thinking is blind, and an a priori concept without personally lived experience is mere formal conceiving or schematism.²

Ontology has this twofold aim: partly to bring to consciousness the more abstract determinations that constitute the content of the more concrete categories, partly to show how those determinations unite themselves with necessity in the more concrete ones, so that the movement of thought deserves the name of both analytic and synthetic; for it is precisely by the separating thinking, the separation of a single abstract determination, that its inseparability from the opposite determination, by which it is integrated, is most clearly seen. But here the question arises how far the analysis is to go; for one person and another seem to take it as a settled matter that the most perfect thinking here separates the most moments — naturally under the presupposition that the synthesis constantly accompanies it. That the separation here does not strike upon any absolute boundary is easily seen, since the finer thinking constantly has it in its power to insert more members into the series of the discrete concepts. But since thinking is nevertheless only genuine (true) thinking by being definitely uttered, it can, from want of fitting words, easily come to drag itself along with a sham life. The thinker can easily come to lose himself in hairsplitting, where the word entirely steps into the place of the supposed thought. Just as speech, by [204] imitating the form of the movement of thought, can be continued after thinking has ceased to move within it, so too, in the transition to empty speech, a flat and half-dead

sufficient warrant in the history of science. It is used in science now of the residue of intuition that is retained in representation, now, as here, of the ontological concepts in their totality, now of a single category in which fewer determinations of thought are contained, insofar as it is compared with a category richer in content. Aristotle designates by τὸ χωριστόν both one of the categories thought for itself and the concept drawn off from particular objects of sense.) — [In the margin of the author's manuscript is noted here: "This § must be considered more closely, especially the usage: Ontology and Metaphysics."]

²This piece may perhaps be developed further, especially the relation between pure thinking and experience. *The author's marginal note.*

speech can be produced. Its proper, fresh life both philosophical thinking and other thinking has only so long as the immediate meaning of the word in the mother tongue is not entirely abandoned. From this the Greek philosophy has its fresh colors; for it grew forth out of the popular thinking of the people (the tribe), and it is borne by the immediate meaning of the words as by a vigorous root. Weaker becomes the thinking that proceeds within foreign tribes' word-forms and comes forward in a motley dress of foreign turns of speech. Yet they may still, for the learned man who has entered into foreign peoples' idiom, have much derived life left in them. But when individual arbitrariness in the formation of words gains all too great scope, speech loses ever more and more of its meaning, because it spreads itself out in the air, torn loose from its root and its life-principle. Longest it continues to have validity, as a merely subjective form, for the thinker himself, but at last the solitary thinking, in self-made forms, becomes mere word-mongering. Herein lies one of the grounds why the analyzing thinking can go too far; it can namely approach too near the point where the word becomes partly an arbitrary, merely subjective expression for the thought, partly wholly thoughtless. The old proposition, *qui bene distinguit, bene docet*, is therefore rather one-sided, unless one lays particular emphasis on the addition *bene*. By this *bene* it must then partly be expressed that the distinction must constantly go hand in hand with the conjunction, partly that the analysis must not be continued until it becomes a contentless, merely sham thinking.

But that a presentation of philosophy (ontology) has overstepped the proper boundaries for the articulation of the concept and has lost itself in subtleties can only [205] be judged immediately by the discerning connoisseur; there naturally lets itself be adduced no scientific proof for it. The proper boundary here becomes, according to the demands of the individualities (the people) and of the ages, of a highly variable nature, so that herein lies one of the many grounds that compel philosophy to come forward in a manifoldness of individual forms. The presentation of philosophy with which an individual, without affectation, finds himself satisfied, and in which he moves freely, is now more concentrated, now more developed; but a single norm valid for all can never be found. We here set up only the general proposition, that the separating out of the abstract determinations that are united in a concept can be driven too far. Treatises in which this fault is committed therefore attract little attention in the literature: they have, namely, interest only for the writer himself, but not for the reader. Such an

exaggerated analysis is not seldom undertaken by Hegelians, who, after Hegel's own method, continue the dismemberment of the concepts at which he comes to a stop. 'How lifeless is the presentation in several of Hinrichs's works! Even Hegel, who yet had most occasion to be pleased with it, begs, in his letters, the author to lay greater diligence upon clarity, and confesses that it often falls rather troublesome to him himself to follow his exposition.

Just as the presentation of philosophy often loses its intensity in that the concept is all too much dissolved into its abstract components and, so to speak, unraveled into thin threads, so it also often suffers from the opposite defect and thereby loses its objective validity; we think here of the superficial exposition that makes all too long strides in its dialectic, skips over too many intermediate members, and thereby becomes unintelligible to the reader. But the proper measure here too depends on the time and the definite circumstances under which the presentation has come to be. — Thus the definite relation between intension and extension in the formation of philosophical thinking is one of the ways in which the national spirit expresses itself among a people. — — [206]

CHAPTER ONE.

The Doctrine of the Single Concepts.

First Section.

The Beginning-Concepts.

By reflections on the nature of cognition, the natural certainty of the objective reality of thinking can be disturbed to such a degree that all cognition of truth seems to transform itself into a meaningless play with merely subjective concepts. Thereby arise such shapes of consciousness as idealism, skepticism, and nihilism, which have their common ground in this, that the thinker first, by a violent abstraction, wholly separates thinking from existence, and then in vain looks around for grounds of their agreement.

But in continuing the train of thought that regards the fundamental concepts of thinking as merely subjective forms, one notices that it cannot possibly be carried

through with consistency. It cannot be uttered at all except under the presupposition of the real validity of certain fundamental concepts, of which one can make use as means to its presentation. But once one has made this clear to oneself, the merely subjective thinking is overcome; the self-contradiction in which it at last entangles itself has been brought to consciousness, and the way is paved for an advance in cognition.

The concepts by which existence is thought cannot, namely, possibly all together [207] lose their meaning for the doubter. This is experienced all the more clearly the more one approaches, with one's skeptical reflection, the most abstract among them. We will at once direct attention to the most contentless fundamental concept found in our consciousness, namely the concept Being, or to be; for therein we meet precisely an insurmountable boundary for idealistic doubts and broodings. The opinion that the concept Being has no objective validity no one has consistently defended, and no one can clearly utter it; for if one does not presuppose the reality of this concept, one can assert of nothing that it is, or that it is not. From this comes the often-emphasized contradiction in which Kant's critique of reason is entangled. According to the plan of the system, Being had to be regarded as a subjective concept that held only for the world of phenomena; but notwithstanding, there is continual talk of that which, in itself, is, without the least account being given of whence the concept of it is fetched, and whence it acquires its reality. But it is the nature of the matter that has here made itself valid against a contrived train of thought: one can assert nothing and deny nothing without ascribing to the concept Being more than subjective meaning; indeed, without assuming its reality one has no means of denying its reality. — This concept, which carries with it such invincible certainty of reality, is highly fitted to make thinking's indissoluble connection with Being quite evident, and this concept we have, as has been said, chosen as the point of departure for ontology.

A Being. Since ontology is here expounded without its scientific introduction, the concept Being is here taken as immediate. It is presupposed that the word carries the meaning in which it is here to be taken; but in the advance to the more concrete concepts, into which this beginning-concept will dialectically develop itself, this [208] meaning will come forward more definitely, in that the transition itself here, as with all the following categories, will cast light back upon the foregoing.

The thought Being is the beginning-point in the properly philosophical or produc-

tive thinking, and it is the aim of science to let a whole a priori system of thought arise through the expansion of this point. In that the concept Being develops itself, for thinking, into concepts richer in content, thinking can with truth be said itself to bring forth its content, and the content that it itself brings forth is a cycle of determinations for all actuality, which have universal validity and necessity. — Sometimes the assertion is disputed that one can, by an a priori or, as one now often hears, immanent thinking, develop the most universal determinations of thinking and of existence in such a way that thinking, after abstraction from all content, with free self-sufficiency reproduces itself in the true form that belongs to it. The objections against this doctrine rest entirely on misunderstanding. But this misunderstanding lets itself be removed by a couple of words, which at the same time can contribute to drawing off some of the aristocratic obscurity from the concept of immanent thinking. We naturally grant that the fundamental concepts of thinking develop themselves under experience, and that the most important categories, which constitute the content of ontology, must be found in the thinkers' consciousness before the idea of ontology can be grasped. The production spoken of is therefore, in a certain sense, a more thorough reproduction, by which one partly makes clear to oneself the relation that obtains among those fundamental concepts, of which one had indeed previously made an immediate use, partly — and this is the most important — in that one orders them, finds them to be interconnected fragments of an original human fundamental cognition. By this altered position and meaning, which the categories acquire after that reproduction, one is thus really justified in regarding it as a production of something new. — Besides, [209] the ontologist is by no means restricted to the cycle of categories that are handed down to him as expressly named in language. While he, in a methodical way, surveys the connection of the categories, it may well be possible that the science requires a different articulation from the one that the need of social life has occasioned. In every thorough ontology there are therefore found categories that are not known outside the scientific language. But it is here that the airy formations of words and formulas can so easily gain entrance, in that the lust for mastery and subjective arbitrariness make themselves valid in the choice of technical terms. Only when this awkward state comes to an end will the study of philosophy become truly gladdening, because human thinking can come to move in forms that accord with the laws of nature and of beauty. Only then will the true priests of philosophy come to conduct its word. — Who

indeed doubts that nowadays those who are properly called by nature to philosophical research find themselves shut out from it by the prevailing philosophers' narrowness, want of the gift of presentation, and dominant guild-spirit. Philosophical genius is surely not the foremost requisite for one who is to be able to orient himself in the factual condition of the now-prevailing German philosophy.

As the beginning of all determination of thought,³ the concept Being must of all be the most abstract; no various determinations let themselves be distinguished within it as its content; it is wholly simple and indissoluble. Therefore it is impossible to give any definition of it in the usual meaning of the word Definition. For that, namely, it would be required that there be given a more abstract concept under which it could be subsumed; but then this concept would have to be regarded as a more correct point of departure for ontological thinking than the concept Being. The concept Being becomes defined only by its place in the whole system of the categories. A consequence of the abstract nature of Being is its universal validity. Everything that lets itself be determined by any other category, such as cause or consequence, or substance, etc., also lets itself be determined by this most universal of all concepts, which lies at the ground of them all. When one of the more concrete categories is predicated of a subject, Being is thereby indirectly predicated of it; whereas by mere Being not a single one of the other determinations of thought is uttered of a subject. [210]

Since Being in an abstract manner encloses all actuality and is contained in all other determinations of thought for actuality, the concept is thought incorrectly if it is apprehended as an opposite to thinking. For thus, according to its immediate meaning, the word can also be understood. But according to the all-embracing meaning in which Being is here to be taken, it holds of all that is subjective as well as of all that is objective. Thinking too falls under the determination Being.

As a transition to real thinking, or beginning thereto, Being is at once both determination and non-determination. This contradiction makes it so that one cannot remain standing at this concept, but is driven from it to other concepts by which it is completed. The need for closer determination that accompanies the concept Being we will strive to bring to clearer consciousness by yet a couple of different turns of phrase.

³Here the author has noted the following: "Partly written during my illness this year (1838) and begun during asthmatic attacks last year, after another failed draft had been discarded."

Being can be regarded as the mere copula with a wholly indeterminate subject that seeks its predicate. It utters neither that something is, nor what it is. x is x is the formula in which this complete want of determinateness can be uttered. By this reflection, that we here have, of the form of the proposition, only the mere copula — [211] is —, it becomes quite intuitable that we have to do with an unfinished thought that demands its supplement.

The wholly indeterminate Being is as yet Nothing. Thus one is oneself, even according to immediate usage, justified in expressing oneself. What cannot be determined by any predicate, what is not Something, that is Nothing. (This is one of the several senses in which the word Nothing can be taken.) By the consideration that Being is Nothing, or rather, that it is as yet for us Nothing, the ontological movement of thought has properly first begun. For it presupposes, like every movement, two points: one from which the movement proceeds, and one to which it goes. By this movement it is here brought to definite consciousness that in the concept Being there lies a lack or a want. Nothing here designates the vacant place for a predicate. The pure Being is Nothing says the same as: to be is as yet Nothing, unless thereby is thought to be Something. *Something* is thus the new category that steps into the place of Nothing, and only by uttering the proposition “*Being is Something*” have I made a clear advance in thinking.

It has become customary, on Hegel’s authority, to regard the pure Being as the category that lies at the ground of the Eleatics’ worldview. Without deciding the question whether that philosophy is with good ground compared with this place of ontology (which, from a strictly historical standpoint, would perhaps have to be denied), it is remarked in passing that τὸ ὄν among the Eleatics — instead of τὸ εἶναι — does not, at least, quite correspond to the pure Being or the to-be, since the hypostatization that lies in the Greek word makes the concept more concrete than it here, according to its determination, ought to be. The Danish *Væren* (Being) is here more adequate than the corresponding words among several other cultivated nations. [212] The French *être* is, e.g., more ambiguous, as is the German *Seyn*, which, at least with the definite article, is also used to designate the sum-total of all that is.

B. Something. The proper advance from the indeterminate Being is the one that is made to determinateness in general. To be is to be determined in one way or another, or: All that is, is determined, is Something — —

[The fragment breaks off here.]